Berkeley Police Department
Memorandum

To:	City Manager Paul Buddenhagen	Date:	May 28, 2026
	Deputy City Manager David White		
From:	Chief Jennifer Louis		
Subject:	**BPD Overtime Summary**		

Summary

The department's overtime (OT) budget baseline has remained essentially flat over the last 3 fiscal years at approximately $7.5 million while annual actuals have climbed to approximately $10 million. The structural gap is concentrated in the Communications Center where scheduled dispatcher staffing sits below the minimum required to keep the floor covered, making OT a necessity rather than discretionary. Sworn officer OT tracks budget closely once reimbursements are accounted for, and it is anticipated that negotiations with BPA will further help the Department manage Sworn officer OT. Targeted operational investments outlined separately (Communications Center technology and the public safety technology packages) would allow minimum staffing requirements to lower and thereby relieve OT pressure and could reduce the size of future OT allocations.

Cost Growth in OT is Partly Mechanical

Even setting operational drivers aside, OT cost rises year over year through factors that have nothing to do with hours worked: MOU-negotiated salary adjustments, step increases, and premium pay additions all push the dollar cost of each OT hour upward. The OT budget baseline has not been appropriately adjusted in the last few budget cycles for these changes, which mechanically widens the budget-vs.-actual gap each year independent of operations.

Scheduled Staffing vs. Minimum Staffing

OT is fundamentally a function of the buffer between how many staff are scheduled and the minimum (agreed upon by BPD and BPA) required to safely deliver service. When scheduled staffing exceeds the minimum, normal absences (vacation, sick, training, comp time) can be absorbed without generating OT. When scheduled staffing equals or falls below minimum staffing levels, every absence results in OT. The table below provides an

overview of department overtime across three fiscal years before accounting for reimbursements and grants:

Dollars in Millions

Fiscal Year	***Budget***	***Actual***	***Variance***
FY24	$7.46	$9.09	+$1.63 (+22%)
FY25	$7.45	$10.12	+$2.67 (+36%)
FY26 (projected)	$7.81	~$9.64	+$1.83 (+23%)

About $700K/year of OT is grant or special-fund-supported and reimbursed back to the General Fund (GF), and another $330–$430K/year of special-event OT is offset by vendor reimbursements to GF revenue. Adjusting for these, the true General Fund burden was approximately $9.0 million in FY25 (not $10.1 million) and is tracking at approximately $8.4 million in FY26.

As outlined in the table below, the Patrol Division (the largest absolute OT line) tracks budget closely:

Fiscal Year	Budget*	Actual*	% of Budget
FY24	$5.58	$4.96	89%
FY25	$5.33	$5.69	107%
FY26 (projected)	$5.65	~$5.38	~95%

**Dollars in Millions*

Patrol OT is driven by minimum staffing levels per shift. The department has already lowered minimum staffing levels significantly by reducing beats and distributing patrol resources more efficiently, which has maintained the buffer between scheduled and minimum staffing as available staffing has decreased. The result is visible in the table above: Patrol is not the source of the department's overage in OT. Within Patrol's FY25 OT, 60% of hours backfilled time off and vacancies (vacation 21%, training backfill 13%, comp time 7%, sick 6%, under-strength 5%, workers' comp 3%), 15% training, 14% shift-extended, 4% court, and 7% operational/events/other.

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Communications Center scheduled staffing is below the minimum, producing overages in OT:

Fiscal Year	Budget	Actual*	% of Budget
FY24	$389,000	$1.42	365%
FY25	$413,000	$1.63	395%
FY26 (projected)	$451,000	~$1.76	~390%

**Dollars in Millions.*

The budget for dispatch OT assumes full staffing. We have not had full Communications Center staffing in many years, and scheduled staffing currently sits below the minimum required to operate the Center, which means there is no buffer at all and every absence converts directly into OT. In FY25, 86% of dispatch OT was directly attributed to backfill for short staffing, while another 5% was attributed to backfill for training and sick leave, and the remainder resulting from events, recruiting. Because much of dispatch OT is generated from positions sitting vacant, the salary savings from those vacancies are converted nearly 1-for-1 into OT, meaning the unit can come in near its overall personnel budget while still generating more OT than what has been budgeted.

BPA Negotiations

Provisions affecting how OT is generated and managed on the sworn side are actively being discussed in current labor negotiations with the Berkeley Police Association, and the department is making progress toward contract changes that could further moderate sworn OT cost drivers going forward.

Next Steps

The goal in both Patrol and Dispatch is the same: widen the buffer between scheduled staffing and the minimum required to deliver service, so that routine absences can be absorbed without generating OT.

On the sworn side, that buffer has been maintained despite reduced staffing by reducing beats and efficiently redistributing patrol resources. It can be widened through force-multiplying technology- Drone as First Responder and UAS capabilities, continued ALPR

investment, and the surveillance camera program- all of which allow effective coverage of the city at lower minimum staffing levels. The public safety technology package contemplated separately is directly aligned with this approach and would, over time, allow the OT allocation itself to be reduced rather than just held flat.

On the dispatch side, no operational fix substitutes for closing the vacancy gap. The single highest-leverage action available is bringing Communications Center scheduled staffing above the minimum threshold. The Communications Center technology package contemplated separately (script-based dispatching software, automated non-emergency call taking) is the direct lever here: once scheduled staffing exceeds minimum staffing, the structural conversion of salary savings into OT ends, and dispatch OT can return to a budget-aligned level.

Taken together, proposed technology investments target the actual mechanics of the overage rather than the symptom, and they create the conditions under which the department's future OT allocation can be reduced from its current level.